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Kenny Davern Part II

Kenny Davern continues to set the standard for jazz clarinet. He currently enjoys a productive relationship with Arbors Records and performs frequently at numerous jazz festivals across the country. Mr. Davern received an honorary doctorate degree from Hamilton College in May of 2000.

Part II was conducted in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 16, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're in Clearwater Beach for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have a second opportunity to speak with Kenny Davern.

KD: I'm very pleased indeed.

MR: Doctor Davern.

KD: Doctor Rowe.

MR: Congratulations on your honorary degree.

KD: Thank you. It was a real honor indeed. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. That was a good weekend. I'm looking at your whole career, and it's a lengthy one, and I'm expecting a lot more from you, 10, 15, 20 years down the road, don't you think?

KD: I'm just trying to make it day by day. I don't buy any green bananas to quote Flip Phillips.

MR: I had something I noticed in your last interview, I thought I would just start with this. You had said, talking about a person's, the way they play and improvising a solo and so forth, "what it boils down to is can you sing through your horn. Can you sustain a melody and make it beautiful without all the gibberish and nonsense and trying to show everybody how many notes you can play around a melodic theme. Can you state simply the bare essentials of a melody and make it convincing."

KD: Yeah. I said that.

MR: You said that. Do you have a problem with any of the more modern players who don't seem to—

KD: They embellish on the actual simplicity of making a statement, a melodic statement, as devoid of superfluous things, notes, gimmicks. Yeah I have a problem with them, sure. They bore me.

MR: They blur you?

KD: No bore me.

MR: Bore you, okay.

KD: Because Louis Armstrong was probably the greatest exponent of being able to play one note and making it more meaning, with a great deal of energy. It's getting that karma going on that note. Caruso could do it too. And maybe a few others but not many it seems.

MR: Interesting. I want to take you back in your career a little bit. I'm trying to think now, you were born in 1935.

KD: Um hum.

MR: So about the time as a kid when you were starting to absorb music around you, what was going on in your household that you were being exposed to? Anything in particular?

KD: Nothing I can really remember. Because nobody in my family — I mean it was the height of the depression 1935, all the way 'till the second world war, there was not much of anything going on except my mother just related that I would bounce in a high chair when she turned on the radio, to the point where I was so strong in the high chair that she had wondered whether or not I was going to tumble onto the floor, which maybe would have been a good thing. No, that's about as much as I remember. Also, you know, hearing well basically the radio, that was probably the primary listening device. And then I can just remember when I finally — you see I was in nine foster homes before the age of six, so this wasn't much fun. One didn't really think about music between two and six let's say, right?

MR: I'm not sure if you're kidding.

KD: No I'm not kidding.

MR: You were in nine foster homes before the age of six.

KD: That's correct.

MR: Okay.

KD: I had a very ambivalent mother. In fact my wife and I bought "The Soprano" series, you know, on HBO, "The Sopranos" series. And it turns out that I really have something in common with Tony Soprano, you know, a/k/a James whatever his name is, he's very good, that we both had the same mother. Same mother. In fact she even has the same voice.

MR: No kidding.

KD: And the poor woman who played Tony Soprano's mother died over this past summer I understand.

MR: Yes that's right, Nancy Marchand.

KD: Marchand, yeah. She was very good. She really knew — it must be a type that a lot of people have for mothers because when he wanted to smother her with a pillow and held it physically, she was on oxygen and they were wheeling her out on a gurney smiling. This

is sort of a curious way of answering your question, Monk, about what music did I hear as a kid. I can't say other than what was on the airwaves.

MR: But what was on the airwaves was, a lot of it was swing music?

KD: Oh it was all that. Then again there was a lot of tuba music too. Big bands were still carrying forth with tubas.

MR: Instead of a string bass?

KD: That's correct. A lot of big bands still had that going on.

MR: So they were still doing the two beat kind of thing.

KD: Sure. I think one of the big hits of the day, because I remember my mother singing this, was "Lookie, Lookie, Lookie, Here Comes Cookie." And then there was a very good film which grabbed me later on in life which had George Raft playing a good guy as a band leader wearing a white jacket called "Every Night at Eight" or something like that, and Frances Langford was the girl singer with the band and she sang this one tune "And You've Never Been Blue," which is really a wonderful tune you know. And it's sort of like I still remember tunes like that. It was written by Herbert Weidoft, Rudy Weidoft's brother was supposedly a trumpet player. And it is a gorgeous tune. And that's what I remember, sort of.

MR: What put a clarinet in your hands as a young kid?

KD: The fact, one I couldn't figure out how to play a trumpet, and we couldn't afford a piano. That was my first love was the piano. Second I wanted to learn the trumpet. I didn't know how you could get all those notes out of just three valves, there was something wrong with that picture. I mean math was not my strong point. Then I heard Artie Shaw play the Clarinet Concerto on the radio. I guess this had to be about 1945 or 6. And I fantasized. This instrument was sailing over the whole band and I liked that whole concept. Plus it was made of wood, which was part of a growing tree at one time, all kinds of romantic ideas that came in my head. And well lo and behold we got a clarinet. But it was a $35 one at the time and it was a C clarinet and an Albert System.

MR: No kidding. A C clarinet.

KD: Yeah. And an Albert System. And we couldn't find anybody to teach me, because it was an old fashioned system and practically everybody played the Boehm, and we did find an old Italian teacher, which was on the line where Brooklyn and Queens meet you see, his name was Mr. Bruno. Louis Bruno. Or Luigi Bruno. And he taught both systems, Albert and Boehm system clarinet.

MR: Well you eventually had to make a transition, right?

KD: Yeah I did. At 13 I made the transition. But I guess I must have spent maybe three years playing an Albert System clarinet, which I later went back to and I switched again.

MR: Really?

KD: Yeah.

MR: Was he a typical — this teacher — was he a typical kind of taskmaster?

KD: Well I thought he was at first. I mean he'd tap the pencil on the music stand and I'd play these different exercises and stuff, but I would catch him sort of dreaming, looking out the window while I was playing. And if I didn't do my homework, I would improvise. You know I just kept the time going right, and he wouldn't catch it. That's when I knew it was time to change teachers, when I said well hmmm he's not catching me doing all this funny stuff see. But it was the beginning of improvisation.

MR: That's great. You were starting to take a ride already.

KD: Well they used to call it faking it in those days.

MR: Faking it, yes.

KD: That's a true story.

MR: Yeah that's neat. Was there a point where you said music is going to be my career?

KD: Right.

MR: A definite—

KD: A definite — I can remember it like it was yesterday. There used to be Ted Husing's bandstand. Ted Husing I think originally was a sports car enthusiast or whatever. And he had, he played popular music like from three to six everyday, I forget what the station was, WJZ or WOR or something like that. And the last 15 minutes he played Dixieland band music. And I liked that. I liked the way those bands sounded. I liked it especially because the clarinet was free. And then on Saturday mornings from 11 to 12 he'd play a whole hour of all these different people, you know, Dixieland jazz bands, whether it be Tony Parenti or Wild Bill Davison or you know, you name it, whoever was around at that time. And one day he played a Muggsy Spanier recording of Muggsy Spanier's Ragtime and they were playing "Memphis Blues." And I was just standing in the kitchen listening and I heard this, because the radio was on top of the ice box. And I heard this instrument growling and grunting and [scats], and this beautiful background like the band playing whole notes. And it was Pee Wee Russell playing clarinet. Well you know you can go look at paintings, you can read books, you can see movies, you can listen to music, and if you haven't had a musical experience from any one of those things you're never really going to be hooked. I mean if a book can make you laugh and cry and the same with a painting or whatever, if you can experience something — prior to that you just listen, you know, like a fan. Yeah that's good, yeah. But if it doesn't really grab you emotionally — and I stood there transfixed looking at that radio. And I said that's it, I want to do that for the rest of my life. I was about 14.

MR: That's a great story.

KD: You know so I was 14, that would have been 19 — what is it 35, 45 — 1949. I was just about to go into high school.

MR: And you'd been playing clarinet for a few years.

KD: About four years, three or four years. I don't remember how serious it was, but I remember playing, you know with the piano playing the "Twelve Street Rag" at an assembly period. "Now we'll see 'The Heavens are Telling' by Ludwig von Beethoven to be followed by John Kenneth Davern performing on the clarinet "The Twelfth Street Rag." And I remember how awful it was trying to finger the Albert System playing because [scats] I got messed up. So yeah, when I went to high school I was lucky to go out of the jurisdiction because at that point I was able to get into the music course in Newtown High, which because they had the only music academic school in the five boroughs in New York, I could get in and I didn't have to go to one of those local high schools. And there I met Bobby Grosso, who is Joe Grosso's son. And he was like I think maybe three or four years older than me. And it was through Bobby that I met his father Joe, who at that time was working at Lou Teresi's Hickory Log, but had already made those wonderful Commodore records with Wild Bill and Muggsy and Pee Wee and all those people, and he was a regular guy there, he was with Bob Haggart or Miff Mole, and the people who matter — George Wettling, you know, guys who played the kind of music I liked at that time, Bobby Hackett played it better than — they all played it better than anybody else. And Joe — I used to eat at their house, and Joe would get up around noon, having worked the clubs 'till four o'clock in the morning, and he would get up and come out in his long, silk bathrobe, holding a cigarette in a cigarette holder about that long you know, and I just thought that was the greatest life, to be able to finish work at four o'clock in the morning — be careful what you wish for. Well anyway, Joe used to take us down to the old Condon's on West Third Street, you know, and you'd see all those guys that you heard on records and read about in the jazz magazines, in person. And so I was lucky. I had my own jazz band in school and Larry O'Brien was in it, the guy, I think he leads one of the Glenn Miller ghost bands. Yeah, he's a very fine trombone player. He was my hot jazz trombone player, the guy who owned the Cork and Bib Club out in Queens was a high school buddy of mine also, Johnny Hearst played trumpet, and Bobby Grosso played the drums, and a few other people on bass and piano respectively.

MR: The jazz life looked glamorous.

KD: Absolutely. Oh we were the only music guys in that high school, we all dressed with shirts, ties, suits and we all carried our own little jugs, you know, we were cool man. We didn't know about smoking pot then, but we knew about drinking.

MR: Okay.

KD: That came later. Not long later.

MR: You had to graduate. You have to go through the different levels.

KD: That's it, right. The different sicknesses.

MR: I have a note here that you played with Ralph Flanagan and Jack Teagarden before you were even 20.

KD: Yeah. I just got out of a high school for six months. I could have gone with Shep Fields but I would have had to quit school.

MR: Oh. Is he the guy that did "The Bubble Theme?"

KD: That's it, that's him. He had five clarinets, see an all-clarinet band practically. And he would have bought me a bass — I went there and I passed the audition and he was going to buy me a bass clarinet and all that kind of stuff, but my mother and my teacher at that time said, my teacher was Joe Napoleon, who was Phil Napoleon's brother, and there were five brothers of which Marty Napoleon and Teddy Napoleon were nephews.

MR: Okay, right.

KD: And he says, "Sonny, don't come to me for lessons if you quit school." Because he was a firm believer in getting your papers. And of course we knew that that was a joke but, it meant my having to stay in school and I couldn't go out with Shep Fields, and he threatened to take me to the union. We all belonged to the union by the time we were 16. So my mother got on the phone and she said, "Mr. Fields, do you realize that my son is a minor?" And that was the end of it.

MR: Oh. So you hadn't even told him how old you were?

KD: That's right. I just let him — see I used to go up to Nola Studio where all the bands rehearsed.

MR: Oh yes. A lot of people have mentioned that.

KD: Yeah. We just used to hang around there looking at — you'd see Benny Goodman rehearsing, you'd see Artie Shaw rehearsing, you'd see Tommy Dorsey rehearsing. And there was Shep Fields rehearsing. Well I said what harm could this do? And there was a sign out there, we need a baritone sax and bass clarinet players, so fine, boom, I sat down in the chair and played. Oh good, what's your name kid? And that's how I got with Ralph Flanagan. I finally graduated high school and then they held the auditions, and word got around in all the studios, all the music student studios. So and so was holding auditions next Thursday at four o'clock. And so and so next Monday at one o'clock at the Hartnet Studio owner. And they said well Ralph Flanagan is holding auditions down at Manhattan Center on 34th Street at four o'clock on Thursday, which was true. So I brought my instruments down and there was a line of maybe 25, 30 guys, there was a line. You know, "next." So I saw this line and I just walked right up to them and I said, "Who's the manager?" "Oh that guy there, George Thompson." And, "Are you Mr.

Thompson?" He said, "Yes I am." I said, "My name is Kenny Davern and I can't wait this line, you see I have a gig" — which I was lying through my teeth — "I have to be at a gig in about 45 minutes and I wonder if it would be possible for me to—" He said, "Okay." And he took me in. Well there in back of the screen was Ralph Flanagan putzing around on the piano and a bass player and a drummer. And he puts up the sheet music and I take out my horn. It was the fifth baritone part, which was like minor seconds to the lead all the way through.

MR: Oh, right, the oddball harmonies.

KD: Exactly, right. Up in the high register. No problem with that. In the alto, the fifth part on alto was also like the joke. "What kind of harmony does he play?" "He plays the fifth alto part." So I did that and I found out that Ralph's theme song was "Moonlight Serenade," because it was a Glenn Miller type band, it was "Moonlight Serenade" the other way around. Upside down. Like "Moonlight Serenade" [humms]. Well this was [humms]. And you had to do this whole thing in one big breath, and it was a long son of a gun you know. Took a deep breath and I played all the way up in the high register, okay, fine. And then, "Next." He sat down, "Well play 'Muskrat Ramble' okay B flat." And we played that, and we played "That's A Plenty." "Okay, we'll let you know." You know, pack it up, boomp.

MR: And then you went to your supposed gig.

KD: Yeah then I went to my supposed gig, which I went up to my friend in Queens house and had dinner and that night the telephone rings about nine o'clock, my mother calling my friend's house. She says, "You better get home right away." "Why?" "You're leaving at twelve noon from in front of the President Hotel tomorrow." Well woomp — away I went. And about three months later or four months later I came back, like if I went out weighing 130 pounds, I came back 116.

MR: No kidding.

KD: Yeah. We did sixty one-nighters in ninety days. We made the most amount of money any band had ever made on the road, I think it was — whatever it was, I don't want to quote any figure I'm not sure of. And all the guys came up to me and said, "Oooh, wow, you're the big time." "Big time my ass" I said. Horrible. It was awful out there. You know, shaving on the bandstand before the gig. I mean it just wasn't—

MR: Tell me more. Why it was awful?

KD: Well first, maybe you're driving through Keokuk, Iowa, on the way to Ames. Or maybe it was Ames on the way to Keokuk. Anyway, the most you might see was a Stewart Drive Inn, a root beer and hot dogs. You know you'd have that and an ice cream. Back in the car, some more traveling. You get to this place, you're in your jeans and sort of like I'm dressed now. Well it was hot. The cars didn't even have air conditioners in 1953.

Some did but ours never did. And you'd get there at maybe five, six o'clock and you're right at the gig, at the ballroom. And there's the ballroom. The ballroom is like on Highway 483 midway between, you know, Chicago and Detroit. And to shave you had to plug in, there was one outlet by the bandstand. You'd plug that in, each guy would take a turn with his electric shaver shaving. Next. And then there was like one sink in back of the bandstand with cold water only and a naked light bulb hanging down, and a cracked piece of a mirror. And that's where you washed up. And you put on a shirt. Nylon shirts had just come out. Short sleeve nylon shirts. And it was the summertime. Because you needed something you could wash out right away and hang up and dry and cotton shirts just weren't it then. I mean you could do that but it wasn't really practical. And so you know these shirts were hot, I'm telling you, you closed up that collar and you put on a black bow tie, which you had to make yourself in those days. And then you put a wool jacket on over you, and your tuxedo pants. You were roasting. And you did four sets, four hour sets, and then you packed up the horn and folded up the book and put it on the pile and packed up your horns and they put them on the truck and you got in the car and you rode, let's say maybe 350 more miles, and you got to the gig maybe — you'd go through the towns at that time, obeying the speed limit because they were all speed traps, and if you'd go one mile over they grabbed you and you had to pay off. So all the drivers were aware of this. And a lot of times you almost got killed speeding on — on a three lane, the middle lane was for passing in either direction going through.

MR: So it wasn't like Thruways and all that.

KD: No there were no Thruways, um um.

MR: Wow.

KD: So I'll finish with this road travail. And what the hell, you ever doze and try to fall asleep in the back seat of a 1953 Buick? What do they call it, where the hump is?

MR: The drive shaft.

KD: The drive shaft. Well the drive shaft was like two feet up, so you had your knees in your chin. And two guys on each side of you. And two guys up front. Well I mean you're zooming along and all of a sudden you hear, "Hold on to your hats, fellas," and you look up and you see two 18-wheelers, one on each side of you, one going this way and the other one going that way, and you're in the center of the two of these guys. Very frightening. And a lot of guys got killed in those kind of precarious road driving things at the end. And then you get into the town where you're going to go, you know you left at about 11:30, 12 let's say. Maybe about 6:30, 7 o'clock in the morning you've rolled into the other great town which boasted of a Milner hotel at $3.75 or $2.75 a night, I forget which, and you couldn't check in you see. So you'd have to put your luggage, the bell captain would take your luggage. And these were very cheap hotels. And then you'd walk

around town. You'd have breakfast in one of those Dew Drop Inn places, maybe visit the local music store to see what kind of instruments they have, because good horns were still relatively easy to find, premium horns. Of course none of us had any money, but if we needed it we would borrow or whatever. And then when you checked in maybe at 11, 12 or 1, you may have gotten a haircut, whatever. Anything to kill some time. And you slept 'till about five o'clock, and that's when you had your wake-up call, you got dressed, you shaved and showered and you went down to the local buffet, well cafeteria style.

MR: Right.

KD: And you had spaghetti or whatever, depending on what part of the world you're in. And then you went to the gig and that night you were able to stay over but you left nine o'clock the next day because again, you had 350 miles to go. So you know you do that—

MR: Day after day.

KD: Yeah. It was really quite hard. But you know as a kid you don't care about that. I think I made I think it was $125 a week, and I cleared $117.50. You could save money, believe it or not, in 1953.

MR: Because the rooms and the meals weren't that expensive.

KD: Right. Every other night it was $2.75 or maybe $3.00.

MR: Well that experience may have put some perspective on things for you.

KD: I expected much more. From then on I just got very — like I said when I came home I said — oh boy they all said, you know, starry eyed, and thought I'd be stage struck. "How was it?" "It was the fucking worst" I said. Plain and simple. It was the fucking worst. Ohhhh. They all wanted to do that. And I had done it. So I didn't see any romance to that whatsoever. So I quit him for six months and re-joined him a year later. I was one of the only few guys to ever re-join him. You know, when you left that band, you left. And then I joined Jack Teagarden while I was still with Ralph at the Hotel New Yorker. And Jack was holding auditions out at the Meadowbrook. And at the Meadowbrook I joined up with him and Ralph, I remember walking in, and he let me take off it was a matinee and I came in about 7:30 after I got back from the Meadowbrook, they had a matinee there. So I came in and Ralph is conducting, and he looks at me and he sees me coming through and he says, "How did you make out?" And I says, "I made it." He says, "They need a piano player?" I says, "You've got your own band." He says, "this pile of shit?" Right from the bandstand he says, "this pile of shit" he says.

MR: He was trying to get away from it.

KD: Yeah. He wanted out of it. He wanted out of that band. He'd had it by then. But he was a marvelous guy in his own way.

MR: That's funny.

KD: A lot of guys were frightened to death of him. But he was a big money maker and it was a good band. We had section rehearsals and stuff, and a lot of guys didn't like that kind of music, well neither did I but I was the hot clarinet player. I enjoyed the last 15 minutes, playing with a trio or quartet. That kept me together.

MR: I was going to say, when you made a move to Jack Teagarden you'd have to play a lot more from your ears.

KD: Yeah but that's what I always wanted to do anyway. I had a lot of experience doing it, sitting in with other bands. I mean before I went on the road with a mickey band so to speak, I was always — I learned the repertoire thoroughly, all the harmony parts, all the what have you. So it wasn't like I was stepping into something that was foreign territory to me.

MR: The whole — oh what's the word I'm looking for — the kind of thing that happens on the bandstand, the etiquette, is really interesting to watch, even besides the music. You know, who solos when and all that. I really find that fascinating to watch. And you did something last night, I was watching from outside the window, I think it was last night, that I had never seen before. Somebody was soloing, and it was coming to the bridge and you went like this.

KD: It meant whole notes.

MR: Yeah.

KD: Footballs.

MR: I had never seen that particular gesture before, and everybody knew what to do. Just play whole notes as a background.

KD: That's correct.

MR: Is that something that's been, I mean that and all those other things have been around for—

KD: Everybody has their different signals you know. This means back to the bridge.

MR: This means to the bridge?

KD: Right. Or it could mean, in some instances, theme song. The T. But in a jazz band, that would mean bridge in some circles. An example of how that could get screwed up was Henry "Red" Allen, who loved to work in a quartet format, went out to Detroit to play a club, no it was Cleveland. Went to Cleveland to play the Theatrical Lounge. And he had locals. And he was playing a tune, "Rosetta" or whatever it was, and he wanted to take it out. So he yells, "George Washington." And you know the band comes back and finishes the last date and it goes right back to the head or the top, and he's at the bridge. Complete train wreck. When it was all over and everybody sort of caught up to each other he says, "I told you George Washington" and he looked at everybody "what the fuck is George Washington?" He says, "The bridge, the bridge." Well they'd never heard of the George

Washington bridge in Cleveland. So there, Monk, is an example of how that completely turned around.

MR: I heard Claude "Fiddler" Williams once, he goes "channel."

KD: Oh channel, yeah.

MR: He called it channel, I had never heard that.

KD: I have heard the channel, yeah. Channel, you know, the channel. Under the water. Over the water, whatever. The bridge, same thing. Channel, under, bridge, over. George Washington.

MR: That's good, Wow. Who are the Salty Dogs?

KD: Well it was made up of a group of guys who had the oldest traditional, longest lived traditional band going in New York City at that time, which was basically the Red Onion jazz band. They are a group of scholars, you know, I mean they taught, they were Columbia professors and stuff like that. And they played because they loved music. They loved the King Oliver band or they loved the New Orleans Rhythm Kings you see. And at that time I was going through a learning process, or re-learning, or un-learning process of wanting to explore the possibilities of well what were those New Orleans guys, what did it feel like to play hymns and stuff like that. And I had a group of guys who also loved the same kind of music that I did. And at that time I was playing at Nick's in Greenwich Village, and we used to be called the slick Italian Dixieland band you know. Nixieland band.

MR: Nixieland, yeah.

KD: Yeah it's called Nixieland music. And this was like our sort of version of a New Orleans revival band that was happening in Britain at that time, Monty Sunshine and Chris Barber and all those guys, Kenny Ball, big hits they had over there, and here too, "Midnight in Moscow" or stuff like that. And so this was about '57 or '58. And we had our own little band and we did this same kind of feel, and we played you know like country clubs playing old Gospel music, kind of hymns. "Lord, Lord, Lord you shore been good to me," "Walking with the King," "Just a Little While to Stay Here." That they still make a career of in New Orleans now. I mean it's so hokey it's ridiculous. But we wanted it just, at that time. And I would take the recordings I had, you know Wooden Joe Nicholas and "Night at Artesian Hall" with Albert Burbank and Big Jim Robinson, Baby Dodds, and play it for the guys that I was working with, and it was very, very esoteric, well done, well played Nixieland band. We really played those classic jazz band things to a turn. And this was really rough music. I played it for these guys and they all looked like I was crazy. "You like that shit?" "Yeah I love it." Oh man. But at the same time I used to listen to The Goon Shows on WBAI. And I was roaring with laughter, not really

understanding what they were even saying, but the way the rhythm was so good with Sellers and company, you know The Goon Show. Did you ever hear any of those?

MR: Oh is that—

KD: It was Sellers and uh—

MR: Wasn't Dudley Moore on that?

KD: No. Dudley Moore was not on that. He was in the crowd but he wasn't one of those guys. This was Spike Milligan and what else. Well at any rate, they used to broadcast those things from London. And I thought they were the funniest things I ever heard in my life. And they would listen to that and they looked at me like I'm nuts. Crazy. So I played them these records, "That's awful." Well anyway that's what it was about. That was the Salty Dogs. We have one record we left testament.

MR: You seem to be really attracted to — oh gosh I don't know if "authentic" is the right word, but a certain kind of historical thing. Like I know you are very fond of Jelly Roll.

KD: Oh yeah. I had a choice when I was a kid when I first started to collect records, of buying a Count Basie album, which had "Every Tub" in it, Columbia ten inchers, three or four to the set, or the Jelly Roll Morton re-issues on Green Label Victor. Well the guys would play it, they were very nice in those stores then, they'd play me a band from each one. He'd advise me to take the Count Basie one, which is about the time it came out, I guess 1946, 47. No. at age 11 or 12 I instinctively went to the Jelly Roll Morton aisle. And I wore "Deep Creek" out until it turned white, until the green label, actually the whole record. Because that was to me one of the most profound blues recordings ever made. You know? Are you familiar with that?

MR: I don't think so.

KD: "Deep Creek."

MR: Was that Leon Rapollo on that?

KD: No, no, this was Jelly Roll Morton.

MR: I know that, but who was—

KD: Well it was one of his not very good later bands. Procope played, Paul Barnes played the soprano solo, Procope played the clarinet solo, but it was just the bass sustained and notes, regular twelve bar blues, the tuba played long tones. And after every chorus they upped it a fourth. And then another soloist would come. And Jelly Roll had it going so that it just kept moving, rhythmically, in the background, and then the solos brought it up. It was one of the very most profound records I ever heard in my life. In other words they did several things, "well how did you learn to play the blues?" Well you learn the blues by feeling the blues, one. But to play them, if you want to hear real blues, I mean it's like listening to "Back to the Land" with Lester Young and King Cole and Buddy Rich. That trio record? There is a perfect example of the greatest blues playing of all time. This was

an example to me of great blues playing. “Deep Creek” with Jelly Roll Morton. Probably about 1930 when that record was made. Another example of great blues playing that influenced me was Pee Wee Russell playing “The Last Time I Saw Chicago,” with Joe Sullivan and Zutty Singleton. You want to learn the play the blues? You absorb those critters. You know. Maybe you’ll come up with something. Because if you can’t play a convincing blues, then you can’t play the music. Period. It doesn’t matter what color you are.

MR: I’m curious as to why in this style of music that’s played at these festivals and parties, there’s very few younger black musicians playing it. Do you have any thoughts on that?

KD: Well it wasn’t really hip for them to want to know this kind of music. I mean period. I mean they claim we appropriated the music, we white folks appropriated their music. Which is a lot of shit. Because if it wasn’t for the white guys who played this kind of music, that music would have died probably after 1930 you know, when blacks threw up the music or gave it up. And they went on to listening to swing or whatever. And a lot of the blacks that I played with who were encouraging to me, Dickie Wells, Rex Stewart, Claude Hopkins, Herman Autrey, numbers and numbers of guys who are all gone now unfortunately, they were the masses. Red Allen, you know Buck Clayton. These were the guys who said, who were helpful and encouraging. You play this music. Along comes this young guy and he says that he’s going to show everybody how it’s supposed to be done all over again. And some 40 years after the fact. And he doesn’t do a good job of it, we find it actually in his hands, and we know who we’re talking about. The music has not really been absorbed. It’s not his, he hasn’t really dined with the people that he’s supposedly or purportedly supposedly listened to and digested etc. He really hasn’t dined with them at all. Maybe he had a crust of bread with them. But he really hasn’t spent, really devouring the people that he proclaims to have — well he’s going to show everybody how it’s supposed to be. Well not in my book. It’s crap. And we who really believe the music have been just sort of like pushed out of the scene. Period. Fine. You know, I resent it but I don’t give a shit. I’m old enough to know what I do and ain’t nobody out there that does what I do, and there may be somebody out there that doesn’t do what I do but does what he does as good as me or maybe not as good as me, or better than me. But he ain’t going to do what I do. So that’s why this whole thing about all these tributes and all this kind of stuff, a tribute to — I really despise that. I think that that’s a crock. They won’t let you be who you are. They want you to hide behind somebody else and make them the reason why you’re all coming to this party to hear — the music of Fats Waller or this week Bix Beiderbecke will be our — next week, oh it’s going to be Louis Armstrong. Oh the Kid Ory night is Thursday. Oh really? And really, all of a sudden, how are you going to get individual voices if you are forcing people into

repertory. Where you're really making them sound like somebody else other than themselves. Not that everybody wants to be themselves, because a lot of people don't have self. You know they're comfortable being other people or putting a different hat on.

MR: Yeah. Certain people have made almost a career out of being close.

KD: Right. Or clones.

MR: Clones.

KD: Little dollys. Hello Dolly. Baa.

MR: Well you're a guy who I can always count on for an opinion.

KD: Yeah well I'm sure I've rambled on much more than you ever wanted me to ramble on.

MR: No.

KD: Does that make sense?

MR: I guess you know you look at the jazz scene today and there's some things that are really positive. It's been elevated to a real art form. But I wonder—

KD: Who wants it? Where do people with originality — I mean there are some good ones out there. There's Chris Potter, there's Joe Lovano, there's Billy Charlap. I mean they all know their deficiencies incidentally. At least Billy has admitted — like I say I play "Sunny Side of the Street." I've heard at least 25, 30, 40, 50 versions of that tune by different people." He says, "Yes," he says, "I know," he says, "I haven't heard really anybody's version of it." To me it's C, E7, bah-bah-bah. See? Now that's what's missing in all or most of the players today. That's what's missing out of their playing. They don't have the point of reference. Like you said earlier Monk, that I went back to listen to Jelly Roll Morton or whatever. Yeah, I used to hang with Steve Lacy when I was a kid. And I raved about this guitar player out in Queens. And I says "you've got to hear this guy play." So Steve said "well let's go hear him." And so we went out to listen to this guy and Steve said "you like him?" I said "yeah." He says "he ain't much. But" he says, "if you really like him why don't you listen to who he listened to?" I go "who's that?" He said "Django Reinhardt." So there you have it. But there's I used to — ohh — so when you hear somebody you say where is he out of? Then you go back and catch the person or several persons that that person has heard. And you go back and you trace it down to the beginning, if there is such a thing. You know because everybody learns from this. Everybody. But that's what I mean, who did you dine with? Eh? If you don't have that in your playing, buddy you got roux, I mean you don't have roux, you haven't got gumbo, you've got gumbo soup. Thank you Ken Burns?

MR: Now see, I thought I wasn't going ask about it but—

KD: That's what I mean, Wynton comes on, "roux." There's a chapter in the first one, it's called R-O-U-X, and it actually says, and there he is, cute as a button you know. "Now you could have all kinds of ingredients, you're going to make a gumbo see? But you

could have them all in there, but if you don't have roux, you don't have gumbo, you have gumbo soup, heh, heh, heh" [scats].

MR: Oh God.

KD: And from then on, every time he got into — well the talking heads kept going around. Isn't that right Sonny? "Oh indubitably. He held the same intensity of emotions as for Charlie Parker with the exact same amount of platitudes as he did for Louis Armstrong." He made him sound like he was talking about the same person. Them talking heads.

MR: Well listen, as long as we're on a few people I wanted to ask your maybe just reactions to a couple of names I'll give to you. We already touched on Pee Wee Russell. Touch some more on Pee Wee Russell. What was it about him that was unique? Or maybe he wasn't.

KD: He was very unique. Any time you want to hear somebody try to sound like him it's laughable because you know who they're doing. You know instantly they're trying to mock — or not really mock but — if you're trying to do Pee Wee, and I know somebody here who does him very well, but at the same time I can't take his playing seriously enough because he's doing Pee Wee. And only Pee Wee could do Pee Wee. You know a lot of guys try to do Louis Armstrong and they ended up really becoming themselves, whether it's Louis Prima or Harry James or Bunny Berigan or whoever, or Roy Eldridge or Joe Thomas or all the guys that were influenced by Louis, including Rex Stewart too, because he tried to dress like him. Or Vic Dickinson who tried to do a little Louis on his trombone. Well I mean Louis was a great teacher. But I mean he also brought out your own individuality. You could hear twenty trumpet players from that era and all twenty of them sound different. Today you get all twenty trumpet players that try to sound like Clifford Brown and they do. And it's difficult to know one from the other you see. And so the individuality is gone. Okay. What about Pee Wee Russell? He was such an individualist he was inimitable. You could not copy him without everybody else knowing what you were doing and just making them laugh — ha ha, Pee Wee. This fool is doing Pee Wee. Not to be considered, you know.

MR: Uh, Ruby Braff?

KD: Ruby is very, very strong individual player. I've known him a long time and on and off, you know I mean, very humorous, wild sense of humor, loves to hold court and does, and an unsung hero in a way, I mean among people that know, know that he is a very individual, within four bars you know it's him, he's got his own signature so to speak, has a big, strong part in a world of millions and millions of clones and sound-alikes. To be able to tell a person within four bars, oh that's so-and-so, I mean that's an amazing feat to be able to do that.

MR: How about John Coltrane?

KD: Well I never really cared for his playing. I never cared for his sound. I can appreciate him more now than I could when he first came out. I just never — there was — like bebop, to me it was a language that was trying to cut guys like me off, or out of the picture. Whatever it was, it didn't concern me. It was not my lingua franca. I would still hold that to be true today, that anybody trying to do that or play that kind of music who is not from that era or a descendent of that era of people, then they're outsiders. Sorry.

MR: There's some people in jazz who teach it who feel like jazz started with John Coltrane.

KD: Correct. Certainly. Those poor fools haven't got a clue I'm sorry to say. I mean if you want to teach jazz you take it back to where it's able to be taught from and when it's the most understandable, when it was still part of the popular culture, where the kids, that was their music. They were the rebels. Their parents looked at that kind of music, oh that's awful, dreadful, jazz music. Even Miles Davis' parents, you know, didn't condone jazz music because it was the devil's music, it was this kind of music, it brought on sexual, whatever, fantasies come true, along with the forbidden weed. But I mean there are the tunes that I'm talking about, that the kids could identify with. The same kids with the same mentality today who are listening to the same — unfortunately not the same music but the same tribal energy that used to go up making sixteen men in a band perform like one, you've got four guys plugged into amplification and can fill up Yankee Stadium with this horrendous tribal music and cause the same kind of frantic thing that they did in 1938 or 1928. Same thing. Nothing has changed. Because if man learned from history he wouldn't be repeating the same stupidity. They still do it though.

MR: How about Elvis Presley?

KD: Well I mean I look back, I look at him now and I almost shed a tear. When he first came out I remember I was working with Tony Spargo who was the original drummer with the Original Dixieland Jazz Band, right? And he says, "Oh y'all are just jeal—" he had a southern, New Orleans accent, he said, "y'all are just jealous of him because he's got such a pretty face." But when he first came out I didn't think very much of his music at all, in fact we hated it. It was gyrations and obscene, and there we are, very staid guys, we're going to play the music correctly and properly. And what he was doing was sort of obscene. Then after him The Beatles, that was the end of it. And I think the audience was crazy. It was Abbey Lincoln, I saw her, "The Beatles were brought to America by the Brits to undermine the black man's music and economy." That's deep shit boy. And I heard that on a jazz show. Ken Burns presents Jaaaaz. That was done, I think it was Abbey Lincoln that said that.

MR: Oh yeah, I remember, yeah.

KD: You remember that? She accused the Brits of sending these guys over to kill the black market for R&B.

MR: Conspiracy theories.

KD: Yeah, they do abound. But I mean there's so much that you could talk about, only thing is it's such a drag because nobody really — maybe they'll care about it in a hundred years or whatever, these things.

MR: Maybe.

KD: Maybe. If anybody really cares to listen to it. But it's just so sad to see the whole thing ending. Instrumental music as we know it. Just stay home and practice your instrument and go, try to get a beautiful sound and articulation and play music that you can experience with other guys on the bandstand, which I don't find happening anymore either, you know. To find a trade off of ideas and just like conversational — it's so rare. To have fun and to make musical conversation. But there's no feeling like it when it's happening. None like it. I mean when you're dancing it doesn't matter what the chords are, nothing matters, it's just that you are dancing and you can do no wrong, and every interval has — it's a very rare thing but once it's happening to you you're hooked. And that's what jazz music means to me.

MR: The music swells up behind us. Nice statement. Just to wrap up here.

KD: No tears.

MR: No. But I have to comment on your use of high notes on the clarinet, that I've noticed, in my humble opinion, that they always have a purpose.

KD: Shouldn't they have a purpose?

MR: They should, they certainly should.

KD: Yeah.

MR: But you know like last night you hit one and it was beautiful in itself but it went even higher, it was like not the end in itself, it wasn't like I'm going to hit this note because I know the fingering.

KD: No. Well it was to end a tune, you know. I'd rather end a tune high than low, but also it was a C above C concert, and it happened to be the root of the chord.

MR: Yeah, but I think it was even before that. It was in your solo and you hit this really quite high note but it wasn't — I don't know, I can't even put it into words, but it was a very musical moment rather than just—

KD: Well shouldn't it all be musical, I mean high or low.

MR: Well it should but it—

KD: I mean it's part of my lingua franca. Isn't it? I mean, my lingua franca. You have to have a Dick Wellstood.

MR: Oh — I'm glad you reminded me of that.

KD: Yeah?

MR: I'm going to put this on.

KD: Ah, the Hot Three. No the Blue Three.

MR: The Blue Three.

KD: Bobby Rosengarden, Dick Wellstood and yours truly, 1981.

[audio interlude]

MR: That's nice.

KD: We could play.

MR: It's good. It's real good.

KD: I once asked Joe Venuti what happened, how he felt after Eddie Lang died. And he said it was like half of me died. Well when Wellstood died I felt that way.

MR: That's something to sustain a band like that too without a bass player I think.

KD: Oh we were brilliant. We really enjoyed. I made a conscious effort to play trios. So I did a trio with Art Hodes and Don DeMicheal, and then they died. And then it was Ralph Sutton and Gus Johnson and Gus Johnson died. Then I did one with Dick Wellstood and Bobby Rosengarden, and Dick died. And then, you know, but after a while, so like I switched to guitars. And they're all alive. In fact we're going to do it tonight, the Breezin' Along group. I'll have fun with that. Because Howard Alden can read my mind, Bucky plays nonparalleled rhythm, nobody plays better than him.

MR: Isn't that something?

KD: Tony DeNicola is my favorite drummer because he really takes me home, and Greg Cohn is just a very intuitive, deeply rooted musician who's heard and cares. Well the story I'll tell you about, speaking of caring, I once drove to, when I was 16 years old, I drove to the Hotel New Yorker at 10:30 at night, parked my car on the street, which you could do then, painted in my moustache and drew up my double breasted suit and shirt and tie and I'm walking in the door and this goon who is standing at the door says, "Yeah kid?" I said, "Oh I want to see Mr. Rollini." Adrian Rollini, who was playing vibes with this trio at Adrian's Tap Room, which at that time was at the Hotel New Yorker on the corner of 34th and Eighth, the entrance was right there. I had acquired that very day two bass saxophone pads from his original bass saxophone that was in the shop where I used to go to get my horn worked on, on 48th Street. And when I looked over, it was Freddie Davis' repair shop, and I saw this great big beautiful silver ba— a Conn bass saxophone sitting on the mantle. I said to Freddie, I said, "Whose is that?" He said, "Adrian Rollini's." "No kidding? What are you going to do with the pads?" He says, "Well I'm going to throw them away." I said, "Well can I have the B flat and the E flat?" He says, "Why sure" he says. And later, "Freddie, I'll take the middle G." And I knew that the middle G was played all the time, but the low B flat not all the time you see? So I was thinking about, I had just come on to Bix Beiderbecke with Rollini, the bass saxophone playing, which I thought was nonparalleled, just the greatest thing I ever heard. So now I'm walking into

this place and this goon is, “What do you want kid.” I said, “I want to see Mr. Rollini.” He looked at his watch and said, “Sit over there at that table, kid.” I said okay. I thought I could pass but obviously I failed. So anyway I’m sitting at the table and Rollini is just finishing up, six people in the joint. Six people. Rollini gets off the stand and he’s walking sort of dejectedly toward the door. I said, “Mr. Rollini?” He says, “Yeah.” I reach in my pocket and I said, “You know what these are?” And I handed him the bass saxophone pad. And he looked up and he says, “Where’d you get these?” And I said, “From Freddie Davis’.” He says, “Well what are you doing with them?” I said, “Well,” I said, “I really love what you played when you played with Bix Beiderbecke, I thought your playing was just superb. ‘Goose Pimples’ and ‘Jazz Band Ball.’” And he grabbed hold of the chair and tears came to his eyes and he said, “I didn’t think anybody cared anymore.” And he signed it to me, to Kenny, sincerely, Adrian, and the date. I’ve got that pad in there. Yeah. Had the original shellac on the back and the whole thing. Yeah. But there, you see? He had given up you know. He was just really sour about everything. And I found out a few years later, murdered. It was a mob rubout.

MR: I didn’t know that.

KD: Yeah he was a heavy inveterate gambler. And he was into them for a lot of money and I guess they called in their tokens. And he couldn’t do it and they found him, you know, legs broken and all that, in a ditch in one of the creeks on the east side, on the east coast of Florida.

MR: Well, it’s been fascinating.

KD: Just a mere bag of shells. You’re a ball to talk with. I’m sorry I rambled on so much. I think you must have had more cogent things to ask me.

MR: No, I didn’t actually. I was going to ask you about your fondness for soundmen but—

KD: Unsoundmen.

MR: There’s a funny story.

KD: That’s why there’s no energy.

MR: What?

KD: That’s why there’s no energy anymore.

MR: Oh, no one has to put out.

KD: Right. That’s right.

MR: But if they’re not putting out someone like puts it out for them.

KD: That’s right.

MR: Yeah.

KD: “Don’t worry, you just stand and play your horn.” Come on. No energy. I know that Wellstood, used to do one of these, and when I’d come in he’d go — and I finally said,

"What are you doing?" He says, "Oh, what, you want me to provide the energy for you?" He says, "Create your own fucking energy, mother fucker."

MR: All right.

KD: But he managed to do that anyway. He knew better than that. It was a joint effort. You don't pull the thing out from underneath you — you do this — then he'd stop and he'd say "you got it." That's not fair. It wouldn't be right at all. All right.

MR: All right. Thank you.

KD: Five guys are still waiting out there. How many are you hooked up to do?

MR: Let me unhook you here.

KD: Oh, right.